

Chameleons



Strange-looking, slow-moving lizards with conical eyes and grasping tails, chameleons live in the tropics of Africa and southern Asia. Over half of the 200 chameleon species are found on the island of Madagascar and nowhere else. The island is home to the biggest and smallest of them all.

KEY

- Madagascan giant chameleon
- Labord's chameleon
- Elongate leaf chameleon
- Panther chameleon
- Parson's chameleon

Labord's chameleon

In the dry west of Madagascar, Labord's chameleon lives just five months before laying eggs during brief rains, and then dies. No other land vertebrate has such a short life.

Catching prey

Like all chameleons, the Madagascan giant chameleon catches insects and other prey by shooting out its long projectile tongue, which has a sticky end to trap the target.

Madagascan giant chameleon

The world's biggest species of chameleon—growing nearly 27½ in (70 cm) long—is one of the most widespread in Madagascar. It survives equally well in dry and wet forests all over the island.

Elongate leaf chameleon

One of many species of short-tailed leaf chameleons, this one lives in the branches of low bushes, and mimics a dead leaf to hide from predators.

Madagascar chameleons

Almost all chameleons live in forests. Some climb the trees while others live on the ground. This map shows five of the chameleon species that live on Madagascar. The island is drier in the west and wetter in the east, and it is in the rich rainforests of eastern Madagascar that most species occur, but many are now threatened by deforestation.

A CHAMELEON'S TONGUE
CAN EXTEND **TWICE THE LENGTH** OF ITS **BODY**

